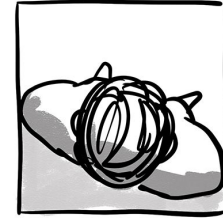


Speaking and Facilitation: Tips & Tricks

Part 2: Preparing your session

[See the full presentation](#)



Preparing your session

Create your slide deck

Even in a participatory session, you'll want to have some **visual guidance**. This will help people remember the reason they're there and what problems they should be trying to solve.

Use **stories**, **anecdotes**, and **analogies** to bring your talk to life. Keep things visual as a picture paints a thousand words (and makes it easier for you to remember what you wanted to say!)

A good deck of slides...

Gives an overview

No one is going to become an expert in your topic within a single session at an organisational event. You want to engage and empower people to work *with* you both in and after the session.

Question: What is essential for people to understand about your problem area so that they can contribute solutions?



WAO

A good deck of slides...

Uses images

People do not want to read while you are talking. Use images and short amounts of text (bullet points!) to remind yourself of what you want to say. Create spare slides so that you've got something visual to reference during the Q&A (and also if you have spare time!)

Question: How can your slide deck serve your colleagues *after* the session?

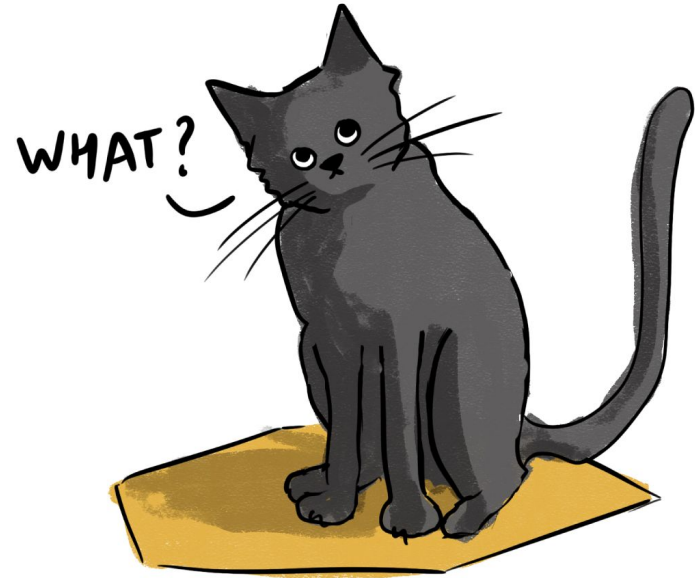
BOLD
POSITIVE
Factual

A good deck of slides...

Has been practised

Practice what you want to say, especially the transitions between slides. The more you practice, the more confident you will feel standing in front of people.

Question: What questions do you want the audience to ask after you're done presenting?



WAO

Promote your session

The more minds, the merrier! The best collaborative sessions include **diverse perspectives** to ensure that solutions and ideas speak to the broadest range of people.

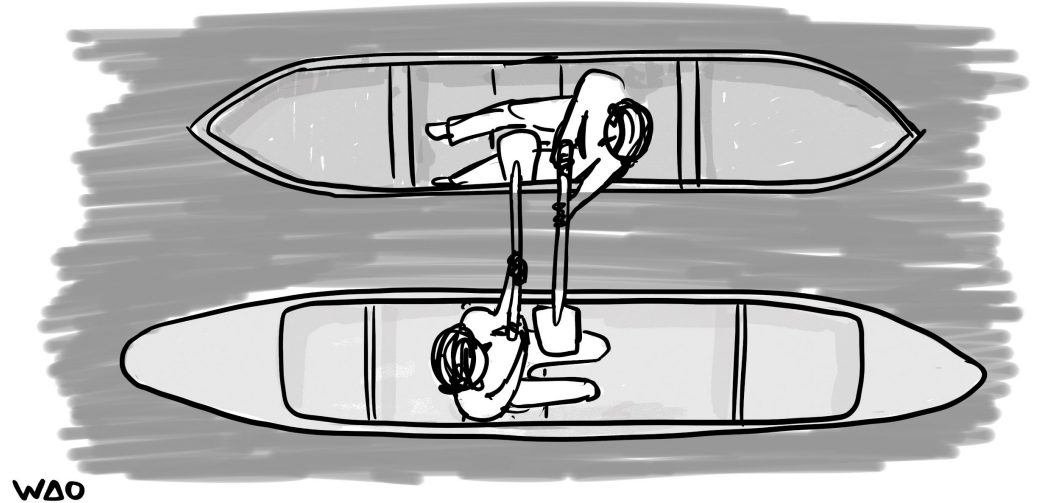
You'll want to tell people about your session, so that you get **lots of input and lots of output**. Don't be afraid to promote your excellent planning!

Get some ringers

Invite your friends

Ask your friends to come for moral support. They can help model behaviours you want to encourage in the room.

Question: Who are your allies?



List the benefits of your session

Create shareable assets

Create three bullet points about what your session is going to achieve and share them with the world. You might also take a screenshot of a slide to share!

Question: Can you summarise the context, need and outcome in just 3 bullets?



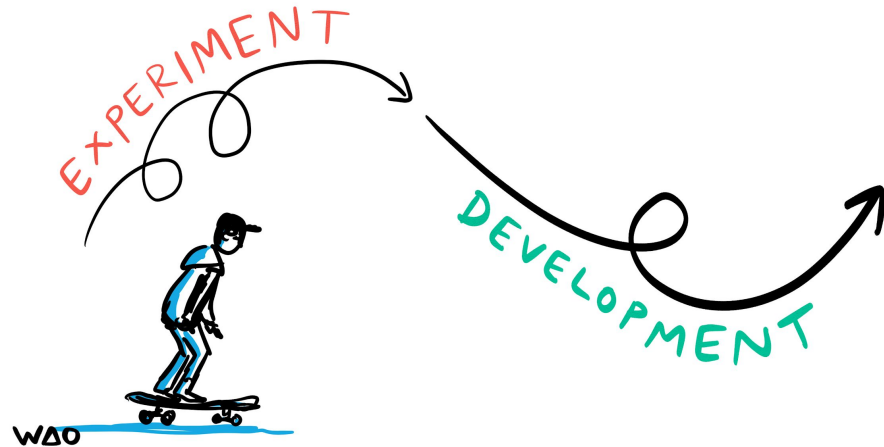
WAO

Use your session as a springboard to impact

Aim high

Your session and its outputs can be an experiment that leads to change the way others think about your topic or your organisation.

Question: How can your entire organisation or sector benefit from the outputs of your session?



Run a mini pre-mortem

Thinking about what could go wrong in advance is a good way to **prepare yourself** for the eventuality that it might.

Running a mini 'pre-mortem' creates a **psychologically-safe space** to take a look at your session and inherent **risks**. All you do is imagine it's after the session is over and imagine that the session was a failure. The job of the pre-mortem is to identify in advance why that might happen.

Have backup plans

Tech failures

No matter how well you plan, there's always the chance that something fails on a technical level. Have a plan B.

Question: What will you do if your slides are corrupt or there's no paper in the room?

Adapt
to changing circumstances

Dealing with awkward questions

Cut off energy-vampires

Sometimes people mean to be annoying, but most of the time they don't. And no-one enjoys listening to someone who just likes the sound of their own voice. So (politely) cut them off and suggest you follow up with them after the session.

Question: Who can you call on to help remove / calm down someone who is exhibiting (sustained) problematic behaviours?



let's assume
our assumptions
are dodgy...

If you're running out of time...

Decide what to cut out

There's lots of reasons that you might be on course to run over, some of which might be out of your control. If that looks like it's going to happen, it's good to know if there's a section of your session you can cut out entirely to save you 5/10/15 mins.

Question: How can you structure your slide deck to make sections skippable?



Take care of yourself

Every session needs at least one **leader**, and that's you. So take care of yourself so you can help lead everyone through the session!

What that looks like in practice can depend on specific circumstances, but in general means a **calm, well-rested person**, with a **plan** and the **resources** to carry it out.

Feeling nervous?

Drink water, breathe, smile

We are human beings with biological needs and impulses. Keeping calm under pressure is a much sought-after skill and one that can be learned. To help, keep hydrated, take deep breaths, and smile at other people (it makes you appear confident, even if you're not!)

Question: Are there particular things (e.g. coffee, energy drinks) that you know you should avoid directly before the session because of the effect they have on you?

DONT
OVERTHINK
IT...

WAO



JUST
HIT
IT!

Think about transitions

Review your plan

The most-neglected parts of sessions are transitions, either between parts of a presentation or between activities. Think carefully about these transitions and how you can make them smooth in terms of what you say, and your body language.

Question: How long will each part of the session take, realistically? Do you need to factor in transition time?

